wouldn't agree to it," recalled Castro years later. The ball was now in his court, but the idea was absolutely new to him. It indicated a profound shift in the Soviet attitude. Earlier in the month Castro had complained that the Soviets were not willing to give him enough Sopka coastal defense antiship missiles to fight off a possible invasion, offering only one missile complex instead of three. All of a sudden they were offering nuclear missiles. Besides, as Alekseev had suggested to Khrushchev, the proposal was politically problematic, given Castro's campaign against foreign military bases in Latin America. There was a great deal to take in and consider all at once.[20]

Castro decided to take his time. He promised to discuss the proposal with his colleagues in the Cuban leadership and come back soon with an official response. It seems, however, that he was favorably disposed to the idea. He quickly came up with a way of dealing with his aversion to foreign bases: the missiles could help defend socialism worldwide, not just in Cuba. He told the Soviet delegation that "this idea seems very interesting because, besides defending the Cuban revolution, it will serve the interests of world socialism and oppressed peoples in their struggle against brazen American imperialism, which seeks to dictate its will throughout the world." Castro asked his guests about the number of missiles intended for Cuba and their capabilities.[21]

The leadership of the Integrated Revolutionary Organization, Castro's own Communist Party in the making, met the next day, May 30. Present were Che Guevara and the leader of the "old" Communist Party, Blas Roca, who had attended the Soviet party congress back in October 1961 and handed Khrushchev the symbolic banner of the Cuban revolution. Convinced by now that he had to take the missiles to save his regime, Fidel presented the case for accepting them to the gathering. "We didn't really like the missiles," recalled Castro later. "We viewed the matter from the standpoint of our moral, political and internationalist duty, as we understood it." After some deliberation they decided to take the missiles. Castro met with Biriuzov the same day. "If this will strengthen the socialist camp and also—and this is in the second place—contribute to the defense of Cuba, we are willing to accept all of the missiles that may be necessary—even 1,000, if you want to send us so many," he told the marshal.[22]